Model Costing - Cheap High-performance LLM APIs

Model costing: high-performance models with very low API cost (5 Nov 2026)

Owner's ask: *"GO DEEP ON COSTING AND FIND THE HIGH PERFORMANCE MODEL WITH VERY LOW API COSTING, GIVE ME THE LIST"*.

How honest this is (read first)

- Six web searches. Results were **secondary blogs and price aggregators that disagree with each other** (several prices appear in two versions); I could not open the vendors' own price pages. Every price below is "reported", not verified. Rows marked * come from **Hoola's own price table** (`server/app/usage.py`, "from the official price pages on 22 Oct 2026").
- **Price is not quality.** No quality number below was measured by us. Quality signals quoted come from the same secondary sources. The only way to rank "performance per rupee" for *our* jobs is to run our own cards (REPEAT card proposed in the last report; Hoola already has tool, hard, long, research, maps cards). Until then this is a **shortlist to test**, not a verdict.
- Names, versions and discounts change quarterly (one source: Alibaba reprices and renames models every quarter; DeepSeek's 75% discount was reported both as ending 31 May and as made permanent).

The list (USD per 1M tokens; cost of 1,000 typical repetitive tasks = 4,000 input + 600 output tokens each, no caching, USD at Rs 88)

#	Model (reported)	In	Out	$ / 1,000 tasks	Rs / 1,000 tasks	Quality signal reported (unverified)
1	GPT-5 nano	0.05	0.40	0.44	39	small model; consistent across sources
2	Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite *	0.10	0.40	0.64	56	small model; audio input supported
3	**Claude Haiku 5.5** *	0.10	0.50	0.70	62	Hoola already uses it as hard-card judge
4	**DeepSeek V4 Flash**	0.14	0.28	0.73	64	OpenRouter's June 2026 post called it the value pick on the price/performance frontier; cached input reported ~$0.0028 (V4 Flash); peak-hour rates apply
5	Qwen3.8-Flash	~0.15	~0.47	0.88	78	conflicting listings (0.14/0.42 vs 0.15/0.47)

#	Model (reported)	In	Out	$ / 1,000 tasks	Rs / 1,000 tasks	Quality signal reported (unverified)
6	Gemini 3.1 Flash-Lite	0.125-0.25	0.75-1.00	1.0-1.6	88-141	two conflicting listings; claimed to beat GPT-5 mini
7	Qwen3.6-Flash	0.25	1.50	1.90	167	first-party price, 17 Oct 2026
8	**MiniMax M2 / M2.5**	0.30	1.20	1.92	169	M2.5 reported 80.2% on SWE-bench Verified (May 2026), top among open-weight models listed
9	Qwen3.7-Plus	0.40	1.60	2.56	225	"price-performance tier" in one source
10	GPT-5 mini	0.40	1.60-2.00	2.6-2.8	225-246	two conflicting output prices
11	DeepSeek V4 Pro (discounted)	0.435	0.87	2.26	199	list price 1.74/3.48 = $9.05 / Rs 796 per 1,000 tasks; discount status disputed
12	Gemini 3 Flash	0.50	3.00	3.80	334	listed as stronger than GPT-5 mini on most benchmarks (llm-stats)
13	GLM-4.7 * (what Hoola's cheap chat brain uses now)	0.60	2.20	3.72	327	in production here
14	Kimi K2-0905	0.60	2.50	3.90	343	newer Kimi releases exist (no prices found)
15	GLM-5	1.00	3.20	5.92	521	200K context; GLM-5.1 reported 1.40/4.40
16	Qwen3.8-Max	2.00	6.00	11.60	1,021	Aug 2026 release
ref	Claude Sonnet 5.5 *	2.00	10.00	14.00	1,232	our premium tier today
ref	Claude Opus 5.5 *	4.00	20.00	28.00	2,464	our hard-reasoning tier today

Other names found without prices (test-list only): DeepSeek V4.1 Flash, MiniMax M3.1 Flash, Kimi K3.1 Pro, Muse Spark Open (late-October 2026 guide); Qwen3-Coder-Next (reported $0.11 input, 70.6% SWE-bench Verified); GPT-6 Luna (reported 0.04*blended, IntelligenceIndex*38, 0.07 per index task, on the Artificial Analysis OpenAI page); Ling 2.6 Flash ($0.010 input, price-only). Reported top end (for scale): Artificial Analysis-style indices put Opus 5.5 around 58 and one source Gemini 4 Carbon at 59, at roughly 6 − 8*perindextask, versus* 0.07 for GPT-6 Luna at 38. That is the real trade: the cheap tier gives roughly two-thirds of the top score for about 1% of the cost per task (reported, secondary sources).

What it means for Hoola (reasoned, not measured)

1. **A three-tier router beats any single cheap model.**
    - Tier 1 (routine reading, extraction, classification, drafting a standard message): one of rows 1-5 (about Rs 40-80 per 1,000 tasks).
    - Tier 2 (planning, multi-step tool use, code, Hinglish writing quality): rows 7-12 (about Rs 170-340).

    - Tier 3 (exceptions, hard reasoning, legal/financial checks): Sonnet/Opus, used only on the 5-15% of cases flagged by the checks. At a 90/8/2 mix the blended cost is roughly Rs 100-120 per 1,000 tasks instead of Rs 1,232 on Sonnet alone: about a tenth. (Arithmetic on the table above; the mix is an assumption.)
2. **Input tokens dominate repetitive work**, so cache hits matter more than headline price: DeepSeek V4 Flash reports ~98% off cached input; Anthropic cache reads are in our table (Haiku 5.5 read $0.01). Design playbooks with a fixed prefix.
3. **Code does the arithmetic** (the playbook rule): the cheap model only reads and drafts, so a weaker model costs little accuracy on matching and totals.
4. **Voice, vision and image are separate price lists** (Hoola's table has them: Gemini live/audio, image models); this list is text only.
5. **Risks of the cheapest providers**: data residency and DPDP for health, finance and ID data (Chinese-hosted endpoints should not receive these; pin an India/EU host or self-host open weights, which the config comment already allows for GLM), peak-hour pricing, rate limits, deprecation notices, and quality drift when a provider swaps weights. Use `USAGE_PRICES` to keep our meter honest when we switch.

How to turn this shortlist into a decision (cheap, measurable)

- Run each of rows 1-12 on the same cards (REPEAT card tasks R1-R12, tool card, hard card), same prompts, `pass^3`, planted traps, and report **correct tasks per rupee** and **silent-error rate**, not price alone.
- Route by measured result: promote a cheap model to Tier 1 only if its silent-error rate is no worse than Haiku 5.5 on our traps.
- Re-run monthly (prices and models change).
- Cost to do the run: with a 60-task card and ~12 models, under Rs 1,000 for the cheap tier (estimate).

Sources (secondary; verify on vendor pages before wiring)

Artificial Analysis OpenAI provider page · Artificial Analysis rankings Oct 2026 snapshot · DeepSeek pricing roundup · DeepSeek discount made permanent · Qwen API pricing Sep 2026 · Qwen3.6-Flash · GLM-5 pricing · GLM-5 vs MiniMax M2 · Gemini 3 Flash pricing · Gemini 3.5 Flash-Lite pricing · GPT-5 nano vs Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite · OpenRouter: open-weight models that matter, June 2026 · Coding model cost-performance matrix · Cheapest credible coding agent API (Qwen3-Coder-Next) · [Hoola price table: `server/app/usage.py`].